Girls Play Trumpets Too: If She Sees Her, She Can Be Her

www.girlsplaytrumpetstoo.org

This interview was conducted with Troy Sawyer, founder/artistic director of Girls Play Trumpets Too.

The art of music doesn't just bring people together. It builds bridges that stretch far beyond notes and melodies. For New Orleans trumpeter and educator Troy Sawyer, that bridge became *Girls Play Trumpets Too (GPTT)*, a grassroots nonprofit helping to rewrite what it means to be a young woman in music. After returning home post-Hurricane Katrina, Troy has organically grown GPTT through the relationships he nurtures. These reach as far as Africa and Scandinavia, inspiring girls across continents to pick up their first trumpet and claim their place in a field long dominated by men.

From cultural exchange programs to school partnerships that blend music and wellness, *GPTT* continues to grow as a global movement rooted in the richness of New Orleans' spirit. This is the same calling that brought Troy back home after the storm. "Our mission is more than just playing the trumpet," he says. "It represents empowerment for young ladies." That sense of purpose has lifted girls aged 8 to 19 onto some of the area's biggest stages, including the French Quarter Festival, and into new opportunities that stretch as wide as their dreams.

National exposure, like a CBS Mornings feature, helped shine a light on the program's growing reach. Troy believes that anything is possible with GPTT, noting how women around the world have shared their excitement about finally having role models to look up to. For many, it's not just about music. It's about finding the confidence to take up space, to breathe deeply, and to play loud enough to be seen and heard.

Question: What role do you feel the arts have played in being a transformative vehicle in building confidence and leadership skills for young girls?

Troy Sawyer: Well, I would have to go back to how the arts and music transformed my life. I picked up the violin when I was in Pre-K, and then I moved to the trumpet. When I picked up the trumpet, it represented my voice. The trumpet chose me, and it gave me the ability to express myself beyond words, discipline, and confidence. When those girls signed up for *Girls Play Trumpets Too*, they had never picked up an instrument before. The first thing that they learn is about those professional female trumpet players, both past and present, who were constantly overlooked. These girls see their trumpets as more than just instruments. They see them as an extension of continuing a legacy and shining a light on those professional female trumpet players, who are no longer hidden figures.

Q: How has the funding you received from BCM supported and opened doors to other opportunities that may not have been possible for *Girls Play Trumpets Too*?

TS: This grant provided scholarships for some of our parents who needed assistance paying for program registration and tuition. And it also helped with funding for our trumpet instructors who are teaching in-person and the mandatory private lessons that are part of the program. We were very appreciative of getting that funding to sustain our organization while expanding our cultural exchange and women's health initiatives, which we are also developing.

Q: Girls Play Trumpets Too is not just local to New Orleans; it reaches global audiences. Can you tell the readers more about how these cultural exchange opportunities came to be?

TS: All of the cultural exchanges we have so far stem from relationships that I have built. My friend and I played the trumpet together at St. Augustine High School, and he moved to Belize. He's an engineer now, and we are still friends. He's been asking me to come out there for almost 15 years. So, I decided to visit. He then connected me with the principal of his children's school, Toledo Community College (grades 7-12), located in Punta Gorda, Belize, because I had an interest in creating a partnership for Girls Play Trumpets Too. The principal was so excited because she had already received a donation of some Western wind instruments. In Belize, their music is more African drum-based and straight guitars, and you don't see too many trumpet or trombone players out there. The principal received four trumpets, two trombones, and some flutes. The timing couldn't have been more perfect because the principal of the school really wanted her students to be exposed to many different types of musical genres. I have had multiple visits and have conducted workshops. We now have 25 girls in Belize who are excited to be part of the program.

Another cultural exchange developed when I was a teacher at Arise Academy in New Orleans. I became good friends with one of my fellow colleagues who taught English and was from Tanzania. When I started Girls Play Trumpets Too, I asked if he would teach the girls Swahili because I felt like New Orleans

is the closest city to Africa in the US. My colleague then identified a school called Umoja in Tanzania. We started a cultural exchange by having the girls write to each other like old school pen pals. Then we set up virtual meetings. Finally, we plan to eventually meet in person.

And finally, we are currently working on a partnership with a local university for a program in summer 2027, where we hope to bring all of the young ladies from our cultural exchange [relationships] to the campus for sessions, ending in a big performance.

Q: What does a thriving New Orleans look like to you? And how is GPTT part of that?

TS: By empowering the girls with different tools so that they can navigate this world and this city, the opportunities have to be here in New Orleans because if we don't have those opportunities here, then these girls will go elsewhere. I was going to go to New York after I had toured in Spain, and this was right before Hurricane Katrina. I felt the city was not going to accept my music. I wanted to be more progressive, and I am looking at the blueprint of people who came before me, like Louis Armstrong, who rolled out of the city. A lot of other musicians went to other places, outside of New Orleans, to thrive.

So, how do we keep the talent down here? We have to talk to each other. We have to be productive. And, we have to bring all of the different generations together to the table. It's more than just having a conversation; we have to be doers and put some action behind it. To have a thriving city, we must really invest more energy in creating feeder systems for any profession. Representation matters because at GPTT, we constantly find and want to find women who are playing the trumpet. It often stops at girls playing the trumpet in their high school marching bands, and we want them to continue and pursue playing the trumpet at the next level. So, we have to invest in our youth in order to have a thriving city.

Q: If you were to look at the next 20 years of GPTT, what do you envision for the organization?

TS: I see us with our own building, that's built from the ground up. Beyond that, I would like to see GPTT with different chapters all over the world because it is a global movement. I would like to see GPTT in France, Spain, Houston, Los Angeles, Portland…everywhere! GPTT is only going to bring more positive energy and change to the world.

Support Girls Play Trumpets Too

Your support makes this work possible. A gift of any size helps Girls Play Trumpets Too continue serving the community and building a stronger, more resilient city for everyone.

Donate to Girls Play Trumpets Too